

LINCOLN IN
AMERICAN
M · E · M · O · R · Y



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I



Apotheosis

ABRAHAM LINCOLN, PRESIDENT OF the United States of America, died at 7:22 a.m. on Saturday, April 15, 1865. He had been shot just over nine hours before at Ford's Theater, in Washington, where he had gone with his wife and two guests for a performance of the English comedy *Our American Cousin*. The day had been Good Friday on the Christian calendar.

Amid the uproar and tumult of a terrified audience, the wounded President, unconscious from a shot in the head, was carried to a lodging house across the street from the theater. The bullet had struck the most vulnerable part of the brain. Charles Sumner, the Massachusetts senator, who rushed to the scene, found Mrs. Lincoln delirious in an adjoining room and the President, stretched diagonally on a bed too small for him, breathing heavily. Sitting at the head of the bed, he took Lincoln's hand and spoke to him. "It is no use, Mr. Sumner," said one of the doctors. "He can't hear you. He is dead." But that cannot be, the Senator protested; he is breathing. "It will never be anything more than this," came the reply. Sumner sat there all night, listening to the breathing that became almost a melody. When in the cold, wet dawn it stopped, the Surgeon General, Joseph K. Barnes, crossed the dead man's hands over his breast. Captain Robert Todd Lincoln, the President's elder son, sobbed uncontrollably on Sumner's shoulder, while the few friends and strangers still in the room knelt around the bed as the Reverend Phineas D. Gurley, the Lincolns' Washington pastor, uttered a prayer. At its close, Secretary of War Edwin M. Stanton, from his vigil at the foot of

the bed, raised a hand and, tears streaming down his cheeks, declared, "Now he belongs to the ages."¹

The continent shook as the news of Lincoln's assassination sped over it. The first telegraphic dispatches after the shooting were brief and tentative, but the story quickly unfolded. How the assailant had leapt from the President's box to the stage, brandishing a dagger, and shouted "*Sic semper tyrannis*" before making his exit. How the actor John Wilkes Booth had been identified as the assassin. How William H. Seward, Secretary of State, had also been brutally attacked that night, and the capital went wild with fear and rumor not knowing the extent of the conspiracy against the government. As word of these events spread, people gravitated to newspaper offices for the latest bulletin. In Worcester, Massachusetts, an older form of communication abetted the newer: church bells tolled at three o'clock in the morning to call the citizenry to prayers for their stricken leader. In Philadelphia men and women wept openly in the crowded thoroughfares, and Chestnut Street was draped in black within an hour of the final bulletin.²

News of the assassination traveled more slowly to armies in the field, but that scarcely lessened its impact. Union soldiers had formed an affection for "Father Abraham" attributable in part to his periodic visits to camps and battlefields. "I never before or since have been with a large body of men overwhelmed by one single emotion," an officer on duty in North Carolina would recall in his memoirs. "The whole division was sobbing together." A soldier in Virginia recorded in his journal how the courier's dispatch was read at evening parade on April 17: "A silent gloom fell upon us like a pall. No one spoke or moved. . . . Quietly, quietly we went to our rest. . . . No drill. No dress parade. No nothing, all quiet, flags at half mast, lonesome was no word for us. . . . What a hold Old Honest Abe Lincoln had on the hearts of the soldiers of the army could only be told by the way they showed their mourning for him." Feelings of anger and revenge, although present, were repressed. General John A. Logan of Illinois liked to recall how he mounted his steed and flew from one regiment to another beseeching the men not to stain their heroic deeds by revenge upon the innocent, but to abide by the murdered President's teaching of magnanimity.³

Sorrow—indescribable sorrow—was the first emotion of most persons. Sidney George Fisher, a Philadelphia lawyer and author, discounted the report of assassination when he first heard it from his young son, but his wife went out and bought a newspaper from which she read the story "half crying and in a tremulous voice." "I felt as tho I had lost a personal friend," Fisher wrote in his diary, "for indeed I have and so has every

honest man in the country." For many children the shock of Lincoln's death was among their earliest memories and would never leave them. Jane Addams would remember when as a child of four and one-half she found American flags draped in black on the two white gate posts in front of her Illinois home and rushed inside to inquire what they were doing there. "To my amazement I found my father in tears, something I had never seen before. . . . The two flags, my father's tears and his impassioned statement that the greatest man in the world had died, constituted my initiation, my baptism, as it were, into the thrilling and solemn interests of a world lying quite outside the two white gate posts." Samuel Compers, already initiated into that world, "a factory boy" on New York's East Side, would write in his autobiography: "I cried and cried that day and for days I was so depressed I could scarcely force myself to work." For workingmen, he said, Lincoln represented "the spirit of humanity." In a poem, "When Lincoln Died," Katharine Lee Bates would remember herself, a five-year-old in a Cape Cod village, clutching a fold of her mother's dress as she shook the breakfast cloth from the porch "with a flourish of her own gay gallantness," when a venomous neighbor of Copperhead sympathies shouted across the yard, "They've shot Abe Lincoln. He's dead and I'm glad he's dead." The mother blanched and reeled back into the kitchen; stanching tears on the tablecloth, she declared, "I will not believe it, I'll not believe it."

balcony, "that this tragedy almost parallels that of the Son of God, who died saying, 'Father, forgive them; they know not what they do.' So here the rebellion has removed the barrier between themselves and justice implacable; and he [Lincoln] dying with words of tenderness and magnanimity upon his lips, forgave them all they have done. In taking away this life, the rebels have left the iron hand of the people to fall upon them." To great applause he went on, with biblical eloquence, to demand that the house of the Union "be swept and garnished . . . purged of this accursed thing." Yet, having won his audience, Garfield ended with a plea for calm. Early that morning Andrew Johnson had taken the presidential oath of office. In words that resounded from the nearby steeple of Trinity Church, Garfield declared, "Fellow citizens, God reigns and the government at Washington still lives." Although the speaker himself later became President, these words may be the most famous he ever uttered.⁶

The people who had most to lose from Lincoln's death were the freedmen, so they might have been expected to be the most vengeful. As a poor black woman cried in Washington, she had lost more than her God, for God had made her a slave, but Lincoln had made her a free woman. In Memphis, Colonel John Eaton, responding to fears of violence from the freedmen, went into their churches, and although he found a whirl of emotions he heard not one word of vengeance. "They were in despair over what might become of them now that their best friend was gone, but . . . there was no whisper against those who had sympathized with all that he opposed." And, astonishingly, for all the rhetoric of hatred and revenge in the hours and days after Lincoln's assassination, no one other than the accused murderers seems to have lost his life because of it.⁷

Easter dawned bright, but the joy and gladness of this high holiday gave way to mourning for the martyred President. It would be remembered as Black Easter. Churches were dressed in black, and ministers either laid aside their sermons celebrating the risen Christ or blended them with thoughts on the nation's tragedy. From every pulpit came the questions: What was God's purpose in allowing Lincoln to be killed? What lessons are we the living to draw from it? Two very different pairs of answers were returned. According to the first, Lincoln's work was done and so, lest he jeopardize the fruits of victory by misguided ideas of mercy and forgiveness, God had taken him to heaven and installed in his place a man of sterner stuff. "God saw this as necessary in finishing up this great rebellion. He saw that the good and kind-hearted man would not be the one for this work; for he has taken him away." It was

In cities and towns across the country, ordinary business came to a halt on Saturday as people gathered in meetings to express their grief in all the mingled feelings of sorrow and rage. Sometimes the rage erupted into violence. In San Francisco two Copperhead presses were destroyed, and several "treasonable brawlers" barely escaped lynching. In military-ruled Memphis eight citizens charged with rejoicing over the assassination were sentenced to from forty days to one year at hard labor. There was no shortage of Mark Antonys to stir the crowds to revenge against the Confederacy and all who sympathized with it. For was not the assassin, Booth, an agent of the Confederacy, and was not the President the last victim of the rebellion? In Detroit the role of Antony was performed by United States Senator Zachariah Chandler, who cried *Vae victus* before a mass meeting at Campus Martius, the local parade ground. The next speaker succeeded in calming the crowd.⁵

The most notable of these public meetings took place before the Custom House in New York City. The temper of the crowd was ugly. A man who ventured to defend Jefferson Davis and the South from complicity in the crime had to run for cover under police protection. Cries of "Bring him out! Hang him!" filled the air. Hope of peace had evidently fled with the martyr's blood. General James A. Garfield, who happened to be in the city on business, sensed the mood of the crowd and sympathized with it. "It would really seem . . .," he said from the

God's will, therefore, that traitors be punished and that the rebel states be made to feel the iron fist of justice. Yet no tears need be shed for Lincoln. Martyrdom had established his fame forever.⁸

The second set of answers, which proved fundamental to Lincoln's sanctification, conceived of his murder as an atonement for the sins of the nation and a promise of its redemption. In the words of a poet, "His blood is freedom's eucharist." That the assassination had occurred on Good Friday underscored the parallel to Jesus. Some preachers, like Edward Everett Hale in Boston, extended the parallel backward in time to the President's triumphant return from Virginia on April 9, Palm Sunday and the day of General Lee's surrender at Appomattox. "Heaven rejoices," said the Reverend Henry W. Bellows in New York, "this Easter morning in the resurrection of our lost leader . . . , dying on the anniversary of our Lord's great sacrifice, a mighty sacrifice himself for the sins of a whole people." There was no irreverence in the association of Lincoln's victory over the grave with that of Jesus Christ, Phillips Brooks assured his Holy Trinity congregation in Philadelphia. "If there were one day on which one could rejoice to echo the martyrdom of Christ, it would be that on which the martyrdom was perfected." The conception called upon the people to emulate Lincoln's virtues—the Christian virtues—of peace, love, and mercy so eloquently set forth in his Second Inaugural Address. No retribution! "I tell you," exhorted one minister, "the highest, noblest tribute you can make to Lincoln's memory is to forget how he died, in the fact that he is dead." Obviously, it made a difference whether the people of the North buried the trauma of the war with Lincoln or, instead, found motive in his assassination to wreak vengeance on the South.⁹



THE ASSASSINATION OF the President at any time would have caused an avalanche of emotion in the country; but because it came with dramatic, indeed theatrical, suddenness—a bolt in the clear sky—at the hour of victory, its force was multiplied a hundred times. The pathos was only deepened by the bolt's falling on a leader of tender and merciful heart. Walt Whitman captured the sadness in "O Captain! My Captain!" The ship of state had weathered the storm, and the captain had brought her safely to port.

But O heart! heart! heart!
O the bleeding drops of red,
Where on the deck my Captain lies,
Fallen cold and dead.

The obsequies did not end with Black Easter. They lasted for twenty days through Lincoln's funeral in Washington and the passage of his funeral train across the country to his final resting place in Springfield, Illinois. He was thus transported to immortality. But whether the assassination and the twenty days were necessary to achieve that, or whether he had created his own monument by saving the Union and emancipating the slaves—this was a question for posterity to ponder. A backward glance over Lincoln's presidency with an eye to what it foretold of his fame is requisite to understanding the emerging image of Lincoln.¹⁰

The man elected President in 1860 was a fifty-one-year-old lawyer-politician from Illinois. He first gained national attention in 1858 because of his celebrated debates with Stephen A. Douglas in a crucial campaign for election to the United States Senate; and he was introduced to eastern audiences by a masterly address delivered at Cooper Union in New York, and repeated in other cities, early in 1860. Several months later he was nominated for President by the Republican National Convention in Chicago. Lincoln became known to the people, as far as he became known at all, chiefly through campaign biographies. Reticent about his early life, he dismissed it as unworthy of notice, summing it up in a line from Gray's "Elegy": "the short and simple annals of the poor." He could trace his ancestry no further than his Lincoln grandfather, a Kentucky pioneer killed by Indians, for whom he was named. The grandson's life was western through and through. He had little schooling—in aggregate less than a year—but thanks to native talent, a loving mother, ambition, and a handful of books he attained the eminence of "a self-made man." He was a railsplitter, flatboatman, and country storekeeper before he became a lawyer. Tall and wiry, with a homely, sad, and thoughtful face, and a streak of humor to match his intelligence, Lincoln made himself popular with all sorts of people and acquired the affectionate sobriquet "Old Abe" while still a young man. A Whig disciple of Henry Clay in politics, he was elected to the Illinois legislature in 1834, serving there eight years, and was sent to Congress for a single term during the Mexican War. He turned his energies to the practice of law for several years, but again threw himself into politics upon the founding of the Republican party, committed to halting the expansion of slavery, in 1854.¹¹

Lincoln won the presidency with only a plurality of the popular vote and no electoral votes from below the Mason-Dixon Line. Even in the North he had more doubters and scoffers than followers. Despite his impressive Inaugural Address, and the successful rally to arms after the Confederacy's attack on Fort Sumter, he appeared to many observers

timid, unsure, and unequal to the task before him. "Oh, for an hour of Jackson!" was a common refrain among Republicans, while Democrats called him tyrant, and fiery abolitionists denounced him for holding emancipation hostage to the cause of the Union. Lincoln's rustic figure and manners invited ridicule, and ridicule, of course, undermined public confidence. Eastern gentility disapproved of him. He was a clodhopper and a boor—"the Illinois Baboon." Charles Francis Adams was mortified by the interview he had with the President, in the company of Secretary of State Seward, before sailing for England as United States Minister. Lincoln was shabbily dressed in ill-fitting clothes and carpet slippers; he slouched in his chair, stretched out his legs and swung his arms to his head, and, with nary a word about Adams's mission, remarked coarsely to Seward, "Well, governor, I've this morning decided the Chicago post-office appointment!" Adams never recovered from the shock. There were distinguished men—John Lothrop Motley, for instance, Lincoln's envoy to Vienna—who worshiped him from the start, but they were few. Nothing about him impressed, another departing emissary remarked, "except a certain lack of sovereignty."¹²

But Lincoln grew in public estimation as the war progressed. Obviously his place in history depended on the outcome of the war and the resolution of its tangled issues of freedom and union. Debating these matters in 1862, two congressional leaders entreated Lincoln to seek his fame under one star or the other. Said Kentucky Congressman John Crittenden: "There is a niche in the temple of fame, a niche near Washington, which should be occupied by the statue of him who shall save his country. Mr. Lincoln has a mighty destiny. It is for him, if he will but step into the niche." To which Illinois Congressman Owen Lovejoy responded: "I, too, have a niche for Abraham Lincoln; but it is in Freedom's holy fane, and not in the blood besmeared temple of human bondage; not surrounded by slave fetters and chains, but with the symbols of freedom. . . . That is a fame worth living for; aye, more, that is a fame worth dying for." These speeches, it was said, were read to Lincoln in the White House, and he seemed particularly moved by the picture Lovejoy drew.* The Emancipation Proclamation of January 1,

*A poet agreed with Lovejoy:

When Lincoln's hand, O Crittenden!
Shall dip within his heart the pen
That writes the nation free—
Then, towering where angels climb,
His starry soul shall stand sublime,
And, throned upon all Future Time
There shall his statue be.

1863, raised Lincoln's stature among abolitionists and their sympathizers, even if it did not go to the lengths they favored.¹³

As the tides of war shifted in 1863, marked by the victories at Gettysburg and Vicksburg, Lincoln appeared ever more resolutely in command of affairs. In January 1864, James Russell Lowell, the Cambridge Brahmin, published an article in the *North American Review* which was a small milestone in the making of the Lincoln image because it showed raw western energy, previously a reproach, being transformed into native genius. Lowell praised Lincoln's statesmanship and predicted history would rank him among the truly great leaders. He drew a parallel to Henry IV, first of the Bourdon kings of France: "Henry went over to the nation; Mr. Lincoln has steadily drawn the nation over to him. One left a united France; the other, we hope and believe, will leave a reunited America." Lincoln was rude and uncultivated, but we should rejoice, Lowell said, that our leader in this struggle for the American soul was "out of the very earth, unancestried, unprivileged, unknown."¹⁴

Lowell's was still a minority opinion in 1864. In that election year, the President was but grudgingly supported by the Radical Republicans in Congress and faced what he feared was a formidable challenge from the Democratic candidate, General George B. McClellan, a discredited but popular military figure. The vomit of the Copperhead presses was unceasing, as in the following parody of the Union war cry "We Are Coming, Father Abraham":

We are coming, flatboat tyrant, in mourning goods and tears,
To hear your stories and your jokes, we trust no more for years!
We are coming, widow-maker, from home and glen,
A half million widows of slowly murdered men.

Lincoln need not have worried over the outcome of the election. He lost but twenty-one electoral votes and enjoyed a popular vote margin of four hundred thousand in a poll of four million. One of the Radicals, Ignatius Donnelly, acknowledged Lincoln's almost miraculous power with the people and his true greatness even as he opposed his measures:

He is a great man. Great not after the models of the world, but with homely and original greatness. He will stand out to future ages in the history of these crowded and confused times with wonderful distinctness. He has carried a vast and discordant population safely and peacefully through the greatest of political revolutions. . . . If to adapt, persistently and courageously, just and righteous principles to all the perplexed endings and changes of human events, and to secure in the end the complete triumph of those

principles, be statesmanship, then Abraham Lincoln is the first of statesmen.¹⁵

Lincoln's second term began with an auspicious inauguration. For the first time the sculptured Genius of Liberty, crowning the dome of the Capitol, looked down upon the ceremony. At the moment Lincoln rose to take the oath of office, the sun burst through the dark clouds of the day and bathed his head in a halo, sending thrills of awe through the audience, then just as suddenly disappeared, shrouding the proceedings in gloom—prophetically, some thought in retrospect. Minutes before, Lincoln had concluded his address, a speech marked by political weight, moral dignity, and unaffected solemnity, on a high spiritual note which, although it fell flatly on many ears, struck those attuned to the moral dimensions of the conflict as the most profound of all the President's utterances. "What do you think of the inaugural?" young Charles Francis Adams wrote to his father. The railsplitting lawyer was a wonder, after all. The address, Adams said, was "for all time the historical keynote" of the Civil War. "Not a prince or a minister in all Europe could have risen to such an equality with the occasion." This man, so much scorned as a "mere village lawyer," seemed destined to become one of "the foolish things of the world" who confound the wise.¹⁶

Just after Richmond fell before General Grant's army, Lincoln made an unannounced visit to the abandoned Confederate capital. He came up the river in Admiral David Porter's flagship, landing from a barge more than a mile south of the city. Negro laborers at once recognized "Massa Linkum" in his stovepipe hat and gathered round him with cries of joy and exultation. "Bress de Lord, dere is de great Messiah!" one exclaimed. "I know'd him as soon as I seed him. He's been in my heart fo' long yeahs, an is cum at las' to free his childen from deir bondage. Glory hallelujah!" And he fell upon his knees before the President and kissed his feet, Porter later recalled. Amid an ever-growing and jubilant throng, the President, with his twelve-year-old son Tad in hand and the Admiral at his side, marched through the burned-out streets to the capitol. Men, women, and children danced and clapped hands, whooped and hollered, and sang "Glory to God! glory, glory!" Many reached out to touch the President. "I know that I am free," said one, "for I have seen Father Abraham and felt him." All the while the Richmond citizenry looked on in stony silence. After a time, Lincoln stopped to catch his breath. An old black man came to him, removed his hat, bowed, and exclaimed, with tears rolling down his cheeks, "May de good Lord bless you, President Linkum!" Lincoln lifted his hat and bowed in return. "It was a death shock to chivalry," observed a reporter.

The march completed, Lincoln entered the executive mansion recently vacated by Jefferson Davis and now the headquarters of the Union army. Whether or not he actually sat in Davis's chair, the whole country was informed that he had by Petroleum V. Nasby, the caricatured Copperhead letter-writer created by the satirist David R. Locke: "Lincoln rides into Richmond! A Illinois rail-splitter, a buffoon, a ape, a goriller, a smutty-joker, sets himself down in President Davis's cheer and rites dispatches!" The Richmond proceedings were hardly calculated to endear Lincoln to the defeated Confederacy; but they fell in with the sequence of events since the Emancipation Proclamation to consolidate the affections of the Negro freedmen for their deliverer.¹⁷

On his return up Chesapeake Bay aboard the *River Queen*, newspapers disclosed the day after he died, the President entertained his guests with readings from his favorite author, Shakespeare. He loved *Macbeth* above all the other plays and from it spoke the pensive lines:

Duncan is in his grave.
After life's fitful fever he sleeps well;
Treason has done his worst; nor steel, nor poison,
Malice domestic, foreign levy, nothing,
Can touch him further.

Did the shadow of death pass across his brow as he uttered these words? Poets and philosophers might wonder. It was one of many moments in Lincoln's last days that, in retrospect, rhymed with the mythopoeic resonances of his assassination. But these last days were filled with happiness. A close friend detected a marvelous change in Lincoln's whole bearing and appearance upon his return from Richmond. "That indescribable sadness which had previously seemed to be an adamant element of his very being, had been suddenly exchanged for an equally indescribable expression of serene joy as if conscious that the great purpose of his life had been achieved. . . . Yet there was no manifestation of exultation, or ecstasy. He seemed the very personification of supreme satisfaction." On Monday, April 10, the whole country celebrated the surrender at Appomattox. The next evening Lincoln made his last speech, a plea for speedy restoration of the rebel states to the Union, to a throng before the White House. On the fourteenth, the very day of his assassination, the Stars and Stripes was raised at Fort Sumter, exactly four years after the ensign had been struck under the barrage that commenced the war.¹⁸

LINCOLN'S FUNERAL TOOK place on Wednesday, April 19. It was a beautiful spring day across the country. There were obsequies everywhere. Sentiment in Washington had favored burial there. The vault under the dome of the Capitol originally intended to receive Washington's remains seemed the appropriate place. However, it was decided—by the grieving widow, Mary Todd Lincoln, twenty-one-year-old Robert, and David Davis, Associate Justice of the United States Supreme Court, who was the family's counselor—that Lincoln should rest in his hometown on the Illinois prairie. Within hours of the President's death, a public meeting of the citizens of Springfield adopted resolutions offered by the City Council urging that he be buried and memorialized in the place where he had lived and risen to fame; and a committee under Governor Richard Oglesby was named to attend to it. With the family's concurrence, the matter was settled.¹⁹

It was a military funeral, organized by Secretary of War Stanton with the assistance of President Johnson and several senators and representatives who happened to be in Washington. It would only begin there, for the body of Lincoln was to be placed on board a funeral train for a 1700-mile journey to Springfield, retracing, with minor variances, the route of the President-elect to the capital in 1861. So compelling was the people's wish to share in the mourning for Lincoln that precedents were pointless, but had one been wanted for this farewell journey, it might have been found in the funeral train that bore Henry Clay from Washington to Lexington, Kentucky, in 1852.²⁰

The Martyr President lay in state in the East Room of the White House the day before the funeral rites. During eight hours an estimated twenty-five thousand people passed by the open casket mounted on a canopied catafalque in the center of the black-draped room. Laid out in the same black suit, with white collar and black cravat, he had worn at his inauguration in 1861, Lincoln appeared natural, with a benign smile on his face "Death has fastened upon his frozen face all the character and idiosyncrasy of life," a reporter remarked. Nearly six hundred attended the noon service on the nineteenth, which was by invitation only. The widow, still distraught, remained confined to her room upstairs. The Reverend Mr. Gurley's sermon dwelt on Lincoln as a man of God who, moreover, believed himself an instrument of God. In closing, he found Lincoln's epitaph in Tacitus's *Life of Agricola*: "Never went thou in the midst of life's triumph as now in the luster death has shed upon thee."²¹

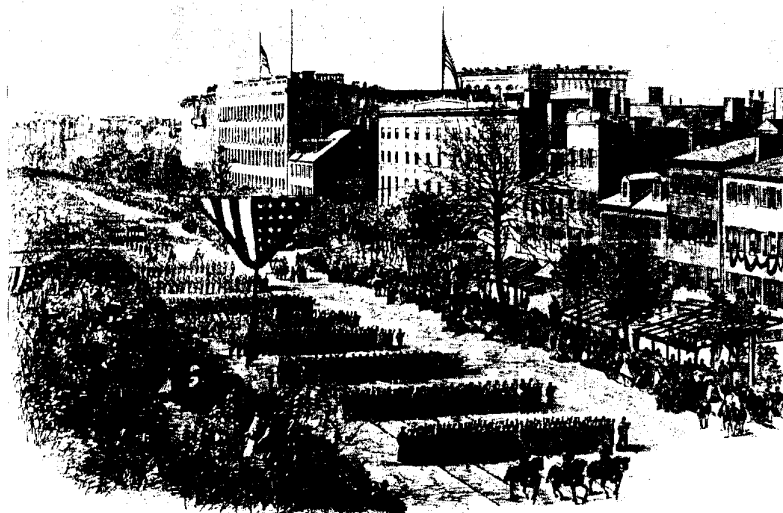
At two o'clock bells tolled and the long—two-hour long—funeral procession down Pennsylvania Avenue to the Capitol commenced. A Negro regiment just arrived from the front inadvertently placed itself at

the head of the procession. It was followed by other military units—infantry, cavalry, artillery, marine—with the bands beating dirges. Marshal, clergy, and pallbearers followed. The hearse, drawn by six gray horses, afforded spectators a view of the coffin under its canopy. Just behind was the slain man's mount, followed by a carriage bearing his sons, then by delegations from the several states, the President, the cabinet, the diplomatic corps, the multitude of government employees, convalescents, Union Leagues, fire companies, workingmen's societies and lodges, and at the rear thousands of Negroes in many groups. The dead President lay in state in the Rotunda all the next day. Rain was no deterrent to mourners. From dawn to dusk two endless lines of black-clad figures filed past the coffin. For some of them the memory of Lincoln's face was fixed in the mind forever, as if carved in marble.²²

In the cities, governing bodies proclaimed the funeral day; business was generally suspended at noon, and sermons were preached in countless churches. In Philadelphia, Phillips Brooks, the young Episcopal divine, who spoke so often about Lincoln during the season of mourning that he seemed to become "an old and close friend," thanked God for allowing the President to live until every black face in the land was radiant with freedom. In Concord, Massachusetts, Ralph Waldo Emerson saluted Lincoln as an "aboriginal man" unspoiled by European culture and tradition. The manners of the living Lincoln had troubled Emerson; with many others, however, he had struggled to overcome that prejudice, and he now embraced him as the inspired leader of the nation. "Rarely was man so fitted to the event." The philosopher thought Lincoln fortunate in his death, not only its timeliness but its manner as well. In his journal he recalled Zoroaster saying "that violent deaths are friendliest to the health of the soul."

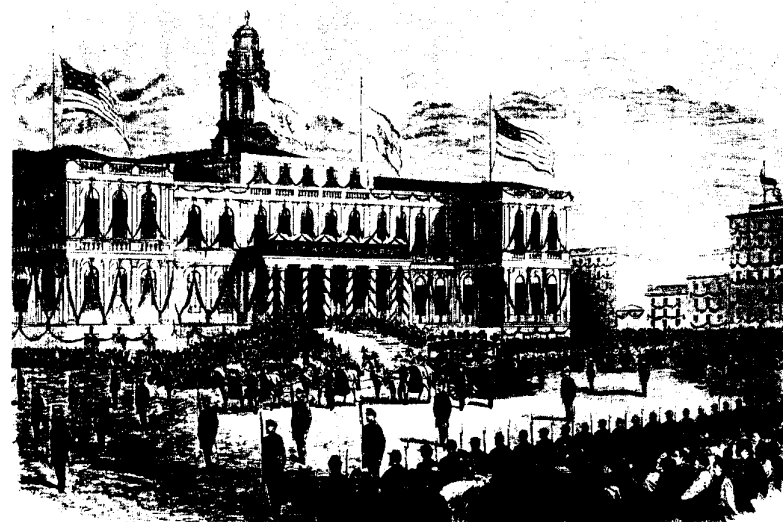
Union soldiers in the field halted to pay last respects to their Commander in Chief. General Joshua Chamberlain, of the Twenty-first Maine, ordered the chaplain to prepare a sermon and had the troops drawn up on an open square. "The old flags were brought to the front—battle-dimmed and torn. . . . The troops stacked arms and stood calmly behind them." The chaplain took John the Baptist's beheading as his text and unfolded the analogy in thrilling and vengeful words. Some soldiers, deeply moved, went for their arms. Chamberlain took out his own. But the chaplain abruptly closed with a prayer that quieted the troops. In some other cities, as in Washington, processions followed the solemnities. Twenty thousand marched in Memphis, and the procession in San Francisco was the largest ever seen on the Pacific coast.²³

Early Friday morning the cortege bore Lincoln's bier from the Capitol



PROCESSION THROUGH WASHINGTON WITH THE BODY OF PRESIDENT LINCOLN

From *Illustrated London News*, 1865



ARRIVAL OF THE BODY OF PRESIDENT LINCOLN AT THE CITY HALL, NEW YORK

to the Baltimore and Ohio railroad depot, where it passed before two regiments of Negro troops. "They stood with arms reversed, heads bowed, all weeping like children at the loss of a father." The funeral train consisted of eight coaches, six of them carrying mourners, one for the military guard of honor, and one—a sixteen-wheel marvel that had been built to transport the Commander in Chief to the fields of battle—for the martyr, who was accompanied on this last journey by the remains of his son Willie, over three years in his grave. The train arrived in Baltimore under rain-filled skies at 10:00 a.m. The citizens' wartime quarrels with Lincoln were seemingly forgotten in their grief for him. The coffin was borne to the Exchange Building and opened to the view of an estimated ten thousand people during three hours.

The next stop was Harrisburg. A pilot engine chugging ten minutes ahead of the funeral train announced its coming, and crowds lined the platforms of the stations along the route. "Battle-flags are displayed everywhere. Banners are at half-mast. Badges of black are seen everywhere. All elevated points, balconies, windows, housetops, are occupied by people of both sexes and all conditions." In the Pennsylvania capital, the coffin was carried through drenching rain to the State House, and under its dimly lit dome thousands of mourners paid their respects that night. "At midnight they were stopped, but armies of farmers, outlying pilgrims who had driven miles with their families, sat up all night to be there when the doors opened at seven the next morning."²⁴

Later that day, in Philadelphia, Lincoln's festooned hearse was drawn through thick walls of humanity lining Broad Street to Independence Hall. There the martyr lay in state Saturday evening and all day Sunday. Many citizens recalled the address Lincoln had delivered four years and two months ago when raising a new American flag, with the star of Kansas upon it, above Independence Hall. Significantly, he had chosen to remember, not the Constitution framed in this hallowed hall, but the Declaration of Independence. After offering its egalitarian principle as the basis upon which the country must be saved, he had said, "But, if this country cannot be saved without giving up that principle"—and he paused with what seemed like ominous foresight, then continued, "I was about to say I would rather be assassinated on the spot than to surrender it." When the doors of Independence Hall closed at one o'clock Sunday morning, hundreds of mourners remained in ranks until they swung open four hours later. By ten o'clock the column wound for three miles, from the Delaware to the Schuylkill, and many waited up to five hours to see the coffined President. At Holy Trinity that Sabbath morning, Brooks delivered another eulogistic sermon, in which he portrayed Lincoln as the ideal American character.²⁵

The procession rolled across New Jersey and over the Hudson River into New York City on Monday morning. The nation's most famous preacher, Henry Ward Beecher, of Brooklyn's Plymouth Church, delivered from his Sunday pulpit an eloquent prologue to the big event.

And now the martyr is moving in triumphal march, mightier than when alive. The nation rises up at every stage of his coming. Cities and States are his pallbearers, and the cannon beats the hours with solemn progression. Dead—dead—dead—he yet speaketh. . . . Four years ago, O Illinois, we took from your midst an untried man . . . , we return him to you a might conqueror. Not thine any more, but the Nation's; not ours, but the world's. Give him place, ye prairies.

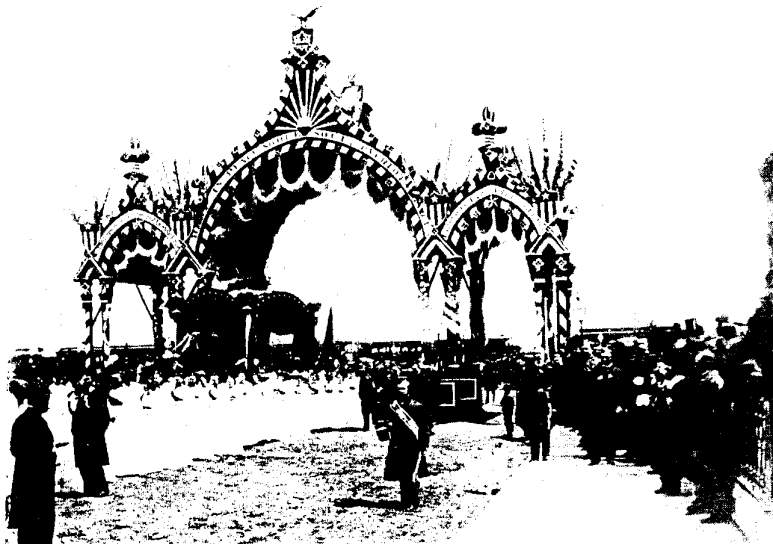
With no love of Lincoln in life, Beecher became his celebrant in death. And so did Tammany-dominated New York City. The hearse bearing the martyr was drawn by sixteen white horses through crowded streets darkened with long streamers of crepe. People looked on in silence; only the sounds of bells and minute-guns were heard. At City Hall mourners queued up to look upon Lincoln's face. It was no longer natural; indeed, some thought it grotesque, the skin discolored, the eyes and cheeks sunken. At least 120,000 people passed by the bier during twenty-four hours. Thousands more were disappointed when the casket was closed at noon Tuesday. A spectacular parade—the grandest the city had ever seen—followed. It was marred, unfortunately, by the refusal of the City Council to permit Negroes to march. At the last minute an incensed Police Commissioner Thomas C. Acton, who had previously been responsible for opening the streetcars to Negroes, allowed some two hundred who had shown up to form the rear of the procession. Four freedmen led this brave troop under a banner inscribed "To Millions of Bondsmen He Liberty Gave." At Union Square, after the parade passed, George Bancroft, the historian, delivered an oration; prayers were said, hymns were sung; and the crowd heard a poem from the pen of William Cullen Bryant.

In sorrow by the bier we stand.
Amid the awe that hushes all,
And speak the anguish of a land
That shook with horror at thy fall.²⁶

The cortege moved up the Hudson to Albany, thence along the Erie trunkline to Buffalo. As it progressed, every city en route sought to sur-

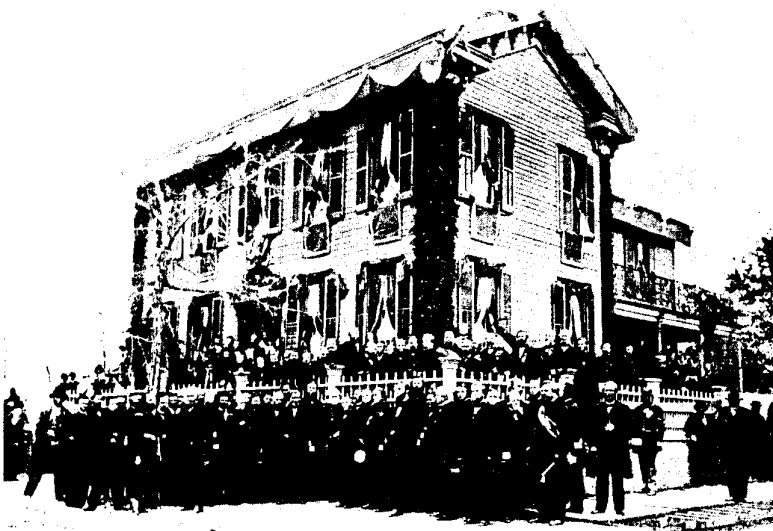
pass the pomp and pageantry of prior tributes. More magnificent arches over the tracks, more splendid catafalques, more beautiful garlands for the coffin, more mournful dirges. As Lloyd Lewis would write, "The thing had become half circus, half heartbreak." And not only in the cities. Whole villages lighted the night with bonfires and torches and lined the tracks to bid goodbye to Abraham Lincoln. Nothing was more impressive, said one of the mourners on the train, than the frequent sight of a farmer in the field dropping his hoe or halting his team, removing his hat, and bowing his head as the cortege passed. Cleveland, Columbus, Indianapolis. The caravan chugged into Chicago on Monday, the first of May. The city bulged with visitors from miles around. The procession followed Michigan Avenue to the Court House. "Under a tremendous arch surmounted by Lincoln's bust, the casket was carried, thirty-six high school girls strewing flowers upon it and walking beside it." Lincoln lay in state for twenty-six hours. Mourners numbering approximately 125,000 entered the rotunda through a door bearing the inscription "Illinois clasps to her bosom her slain but glorified son" and exited under the legend "The beauty of Israel is slain upon the high places."²⁷

The funeral train reached its destination on May 3, twenty days after the assassination in Washington. (The assassin, Booth, had preceded Lincoln to the grave.) Emotions ran high in Springfield. Everyone remembered Lincoln's affectionate farewell in February 1861: "Here I have lived a quarter of a century, and have passed from a young to an old man. . . . I now leave, not knowing when, or whether ever, I shall return, with a task before me greater than that which rested upon Washington." The town fathers, with the Governor's support, had made plans to bury Lincoln, initially in a temporary vault, on grounds acquired near the city's center, upon which a fitting tomb and monument would be erected. However, Mrs. Lincoln objected to the separation of her husband's remains from those of other members of the family, beginning with the lamented Willie, and insisted upon burial in a newly opened wooded cemetery, Oak Ridge, on the outskirts of Springfield. She prevailed. Lincoln's open casket rested in Representatives Hall in the State House, whose walls had once resounded to the "House Divided" speech. The last tears shed over his body were the tears of his friends and neighbors of central Illinois. On Thursday afternoon, the fourth of May, a huge, sweating throng marched to Oak Ridge, where Methodist Bishop Matthew Simpson delivered the last ponderous eulogy over the deceased. The services closed with a hymn sung to hallow the grave of the immortal:



The Funeral Procession in Chicago. (Illinois State Historical Library)

Mourners before the Lincoln Home in Springfield. (Illinois State Historical Library)



This consecrated spot shall be
To Freedom ever dear
And Freedom's son of every race
Shall weep and worship here.
O God! before whom we, in tears,
Our fallen Chief deplore;
Grant that the cause, for which he died,
May live forever more.

The Reverend Mr. Gurley, the author of the hymn, then delivered the final benediction.²⁸

Thus ended the grandest funeral spectacle in the history of the world. An estimated one million people had looked upon the martyr's face. This was the stuff of myth and legend. Prairie farmers would say the brown thrush did not sing for a year after Lincoln's death. Watchmakers' clocks, according to a persistent legend, were henceforth set at 7:22, forever to mark the time of that death. After such a spectacle few men cared to dispute Lincoln's heroic epitaph. The worst effect was yet unrealized, a journalist suggested: "It has made it impossible to speak the truth of Abraham Lincoln hereafter." Observers remarked on the pervasive unity and depth of feeling among the bereaved, and wondered whether the cause lay with the events Lincoln made or with the character of the man himself. The people, rather the white people, of the states of the defeated Confederacy were doubtless an exception—a significant exception—but in the North even Copperhead Democrats, like Clement Vallandigham and the editors of the *New York World*, repented and acknowledged Lincoln's greatness.²⁹

Among the poets, Walt Whitman summoned the inspiration to engrave the funeral permanently in American memory.* Whitman, oddly, had never met Lincoln, though in his comings and goings as a "wound dresser" in Washington he had observed him so often, and so admiringly, that he seemed a friend. "When Lilacs Last in the Dooryard

*Of other poems of the apotheosis, Richard Henry Stoddard's *Abraham Lincoln. An Horatian Ode* (New York, 1865) most effectively incorporates the processional theme:

Go darkly borne, from State to State,
Whose loyal, sorrowing cities wait
To honor all they can
The dust of that good man.
Go, grandly borne, with such a train
As greatest kings might die to gain
Thus the just, the wise, the brave,
Attend thee to the grave.

Bloom'd" is a deeply felt elegy in which the theme of love and death and mourning merges into a hymn of praise for the nation. The poem employs three symbols from nature. The lilac outside the door, "with delicate-color'd blossoms and heart-shaped leaves of rich green," will be forever associated with the poet's mourning. The evening star, which in that spring hung low in the western sky and burned unusually bright before falling, represents his departed comrade. The hermit thrush, described to Whitman by a naturalist and friend as "the most sweet and solemn of all our songsters, heard at twilight in the dusky cedars," warbles "the carol of death."

Ever-returning spring, trinity sure to me you bring,
Lilac blooming perennial and drooping star in the west,
And thought of him I love.

Having formed these symbols into a sustained threnody, the poet breaks off a sprig of lilac and lays it on Lincoln's coffin.

Coffin that passes through lanes and streets,
Through day and night with the great cloud darkening the land,
With the pomp of the inloop'd flags with the cities draped in black,
With the show of the States themselves as of crepe-veil'd women, standing,
With processions long and winding and the flambeaus of the night,
With countless torches lit, with the silent sea of faces and the unbared
heads,
With the waiting depot, the arriving coffin, and the sombre faces,
With dirges through the night, with the thousand voices rising strong and
solemn,
With all the mournful voices of the dirges pour'd around the coffin,
The dim-lit churches and the shuddering organs—where amid these you
journey,
With the tolling tolling bells' perpetual clang,
Here, coffin that slowly passes.
I give you my sprig of lilac.

The poet asks what pictures he should hang on the walls of the burial-house of him he loves, and breaks into a love chant for America reminiscent of *Leaves of Grass*. The pictures are of "fresh sweet herbage under foot," "Manhattan with spires," "Ohio's shores and flashing Missouri." The person of Lincoln has no presence in the poem, nor is it about his services and ideals. It is a love song

For the sweetest, wisest soul of all my days—and this for his dear sake,
Lilac and star and bird twined with the chant of my soul,
There in the fragrant pines and cedars dusk and dim.³⁰

The nation's show of mourning did not end when Lincoln's body was laid to rest in Springfield. His sacrifice could not be forgotten amid events celebrating the victory of Union arms. The greatest of these was the last review of the Army of the Potomac in the nation's capital on May 23. General Chamberlain, as he marched at the head of his soldiers before the reviewing stand occupied by President Johnson, General Grant, members of the cabinet, foreign ambassadors, and other dignitaries, felt the absence of the hero of it all. "But we miss the deep, sad eyes of Lincoln coming to review us after each sore trial. Something is lacking in our hearts now—even in this supreme hour." In perhaps the most imaginative lyric of the apotheosis save Whitman's, Henry Howard Brownell invoked the Grand Review:

Grandest of mortal sights
The sun-browned ranks to view—
The colors rag'd in a hundred fights
And the dusty Frocks of Blue!

Unhappily, the soldiers on marching by did not meet Father Abraham's eye, but the poet conjures up a grander review of all the lost battalions in heaven. The colors ripple, the drums roll, as all the faithful dead salute their President.

For thee, O Father we died!
And we did not die in vain,

...

Close round him, hearts of pride!
Press near him, side by side,—
Our Father is not alone!
For the Holy Right he died,
And Christ, the Crucified
Waits to welcome his own.³¹

President Johnson, in official acknowledgment of Lincoln's death, proclaimed a national day of fasting and prayer on June 1. The Fast Day sermons generally turned into eulogies of Lincoln and praise of his moral and spiritual virtues. Boston chose this day for its tribute. Church services in the forenoon were followed by a grand parade in eight divisions, which wended its way through the crooked streets and stopped before the

Music Hall at 4:00 p.m. There the observances included a choral hymn written by the city's poet laureate, Oliver Wendell Holmes. Sung to the music of Luther's "Judgment Hymn," it implored God to be "thy orphaned Israel's friend" and with the blood of the father wash away the sins of the children.

The program was chiefly memorable for Charles Sumner's eulogy, "Promises of the Declaration of Independence and Abraham Lincoln." The Senator pointed out that this was only the second time the American people had been summoned by the President to unite on an appointed day to commemorate the death of a great leader, the first having been George Washington. There was, moreover, a hidden link between these events, for Lincoln completed the work began by Washington. His turning in the 1850s to the promise of liberty and equality in the Declaration of Independence, then clinging to it "with all the grasp of his soul"—"this grand pertinacity"—was the most interesting incident in his biography and his chief title to glory. Sumner seemed to have a clearer view of this matter than anyone else. In the end, he thought, "it was the sacrificial consecration of those primal truths embodied in the birthday Declaration of the Republic, which he had so often vindicated, and for which he had announced his willingness to die," that caused Lincoln's death. Sumner, of course, had thought Lincoln slow to act on these truths, yet he had acted, and for the prodigious achievement of emancipation commanded a great place in history. His example, moreover, was "authority for the future." The Senator finally turned his eulogy into a stump speech for Negro suffrage.³²

The voice of Europe, of the world, on the assassination was heard in the United States in May and June. English opinion had been overwhelmingly unfriendly to President Lincoln, a mixture of calumny, contempt, and ridicule. It had begun to change for the better, however, after the Emancipation Proclamation and the Gettysburg Address. Goldwin Smith, professor of modern history at Oxford, wrote an appreciative article in *Macmillan's* magazine. The President's reelection exhibited his strength with the people, and with the noble Second Inaugural Address his reputation soared. The assassination struck everywhere, William Gladstone said, "with a thrill of horror." John Bright, always Lincoln's friend and advocate, thought no event had created such a sensation in fifty years. "The whole people positively mourn," he wrote to Sumner, "and it would seem as if again we were one nation with you, so universal is the grief." Even the *London Times* made amends. But no publication had had so much fun at Lincoln's expense as *Punch*. Tom Taylor, who, curiously, was the author of *Our American Cousin*, penned the magazine's apology under a cartoon, "Britannia Sympathizes with Colum-

bia," in which Britannia tearfully lays a wreath at the martyr's bier. What! the poet asks, you who with mocking pencil traced his "length of shambling limb . . . his unkempt, bristling hair . . . his garb uncouth . . . his lack of all we prize as debonair"?

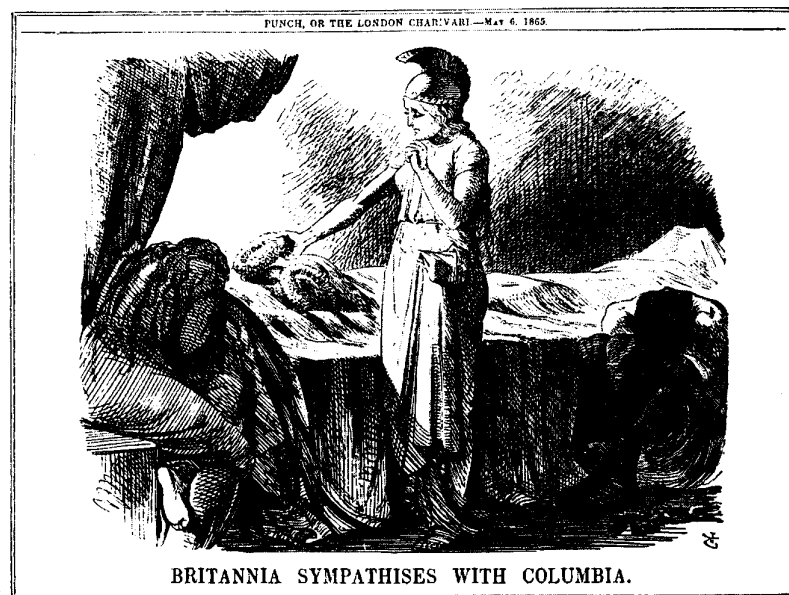
Yes, he had lived to shame me for my sneer,
To lame my pencil, and confute my pen—
To make me own this kind of prince's peer,
The rail-splitter a true-born king of men.*³³

The verdict in France, where there had always been more sympathy for the United States, was even more emphatic. The Comte de Montalembert, a prominent writer, in a leading review, said the United States had astonished the world by placing a common man at the head of affairs, yet under his leadership had vindicated not only its Constitution but liberty, democracy, and humanity. Lincoln's eulogy was everywhere, and it behooved Frenchmen "to engrave in our souls with our lives this pure and noble memory." John Bigelow, the American minister in Paris, was amazed by the outpouring of grief. The French Academy offered a prize for the best poem on "La Mort du President Lincoln." Forty thousand French citizens subscribed to a memorial medal for presentation to Mrs. Lincoln. "Tell Mrs. Lincoln," Bigelow was instructed when he received the medal, "that in this little box is the heart of France."

That the nations of the world should send condolences upon the death of a foreign head of state was to be expected, but all ranks and conditions of men grieved for Abraham Lincoln, as if to say that in homage to him all men were brothers. The address of the citizens of an Italian village declared, "Abraham Lincoln was not yours only—he was also ours . . . a brother whose great mind and fearless conscience guided a people to union, and courageously uprooted slavery." The legation at Bern sent to the Secretary of State two bound volumes of three hundred addresses from twenty-one Swiss cantons, municipal governments, and associations, plus twenty thousand signatures, "the aggregate and congregate voice of all Switzerland." The government of Argentina proclaimed three days of mourning. In Santiago and Valparaiso, Chile, men wept in the streets, passed resolutions, and marched in processions to honor the man who was "the incarnation of modern democracy."

*To which Alice Cary made a devastating retort:

What need hath he now of a tardy crown,
His name from mocking jest and sneer to save
When every ploughman turns his furrow down
As soft as though it fell upon his grave.



Cartoon by John Tenniel in *Punch*, 1865.

The full extent of international tribute would become manifest upon the government's publication early in the new year of a 717-page volume, with the cheerless title *Appendix to the Diplomatic Correspondence of 1865*, in which the condolences were gathered. As a historian has said, it is "one of the most interesting and deeply affecting books in the English language." The assassination of Lincoln touched the world's heart because Lincoln was the human being he was, but it also impressed itself on the mind of the world because the nation's survival and triumph over this catastrophe proved the strength and resiliency of American democracy.³⁴

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THE APOTHEOSIS OF Abraham Lincoln had to do with myth as well as history, but remembered history is always penetrated with myth. The martyr was instantaneously deified both because of the dramatic structure of the events surrounding his death and because of public esteem for him as a man and statesman. The image people had of Lincoln—the way they perceived, thought, and felt about him—was inseparable from the Civil War. Yet in his magnificent humanity Lincoln transcended the war. Indeed, for many in the North, his person and his character constituted the chief glory of the war; and as its colors faded into the past, the memory of Lincoln became the most treasured legacy

of that conflict. The immediate aftermath of his death was hardly the time to form a just estimate of Lincoln's place in history; nevertheless, editors, politicians, poets, portraitists, and preachers essayed that task. Five main themes run through this work, and like the movements of a symphony they interpret and reinterpret each other. These themes present Lincoln as Savior of the Union, Great Emancipator, Man of the People, the First American, and the Self-made Man. Nationality, Humanity, Democracy, Americanism, and the individual opportunity which is its essence: these are the building blocks of the Lincoln image.³⁵

Lincoln's great object in the war was to preserve the Union, and he died in the knowledge he had succeeded. Again and again, to the Confederate leaders who would destroy the Union and to the abolitionists whose primary purpose was emancipation of the slaves, Lincoln underscored his resolve. As he wrote in a famous letter to Horace Greeley in 1862, "My paramount object in this struggle is to save the Union . . . If I could save the Union without freeing *any* slave I would do it, and if I could save it freeing *all* the slaves I would do it, and if I could save it by freeing some and leaving others alone I would also do that." The victory of northern arms crushed state sovereignty and established the permanency and supremacy of the Union. "Beginning in darkness and doubt," a writer in the *North American Review* observed, "national interests and policy have insensibly conquered the first place in the estimation of the people." The fiery furnace of war had forged a new nation, a new people, for whom nationality was almost a religion, declared Yale theologian Horace Bushnell. "We have gotten a pitch of the grand, new, Abrahamic statesmanship, unsophisticated, honest and real." In the political catechism of Union Leagues, Loyal Legion commanderies, and the Grand Army of the Republic formed in the war's aftermath, the first lesson taught by Lincoln's life was the inviolability of the American Union. And the lesson taught by his death was the heroic sacrifice needed to sanctify the nation. "The blood of the martyrs was the seed of the church," editorialized a Philadelphia newspaper. "So the blood of the noble martyr to the cause of freedom will be the seed that will fructify to the great blessing of this nation."³⁶

Lincoln's name was constantly coupled with Washington's. In fact, that began before the President's death, but the apotheosis firmly enforced the pairing in the public mind. Funeral banners proclaimed, "Washington the Father, Lincoln the Savior." Their portraits, with vignettes of their lives and deeds, were joined in lithographs by Currier and Ives and other printmakers. An old engraving of Washington's apotheosis was adapted to serve Lincoln's, while John Sartain inserted Washington among the angels ushering Lincoln into heaven. The six-



Abraham Lincoln the Martyr Victorious. Engraving by John Sartain, 1865.

teenth President, like the first, was that historical rarity, a great and powerful man who was also good. Not surprisingly, some people urged that he be entombed beside Washington at Mount Vernon. Of course, there was more to contrast than to compare between Washington and Lincoln. Even if it could be argued that the latter completed the work begun by the former, Washington, as Sumner pointed out, had been quite oblivious to the conception of a nation founded on Jefferson's proposition

"that all men are created equal." Washington, too, was a god in the South as well as the North. He remained, as he had always been, a truly national hero, while Lincoln was, and for some time would remain, a partial one. Lincoln might be a symbol of nationality, reborn and reinvigorated, but he had almost no place in the hearts of a large portion of his countrymen. Mainly for this reason Lincoln did not displace Washington's paramouncy in the nation's pantheon. Yet there were those, like Rutherford B. Hayes, the Ohio Republican, who dissented from the usual qualification of Lincoln's greatness: "second only to Washington." Said Hayes, "The truth is, if it were not sacrilege, I should say Lincoln is overshadowing Washington. Washington is formal, statue-like—a figure for exhibition. But both men were necessary to complete our history. Neither could have done the other's work."³⁷

Lincoln's fame as the Great Emancipator flowed from the Emancipation Proclamation, announced September 22, 1862, and decreed January 1, 1863. "Now who had done the greatest deed / Which History has ever known?" wrote a Union journalist of these events.

And who in Freedom's direst need
Became her bravest champion?
Who a whole continent set free?
Who killed the curse and broke the ban
Which made a lie of liberty?
You, Father Abraham—you're the man!

The fact that the Emancipation Proclamation freed virtually no slaves, since it extended only to areas still in rebellion against the United States, did not deter the enthusiasm of abolitionists, white and black. The war had been "invested with sanctity," Frederick Douglass said. The President who "began by playing Pharaoh . . . ended by playing Moses." Driven by his "grand pertinacity," Lincoln became convinced that for the Union to live slavery must die. The Thirteenth Amendment added the necessary constitutional sanction. Among the many icons generated by the war, perhaps none left a more vivid impression than Francis B. Carpenter's painting *The First Reading of the Emancipation Proclamation Before the Cabinet*. It was exhibited in the Rotunda of the Capitol before Lincoln's second inauguration and then toured the northern cities. Engravings of it were hung in homes, public offices, and schoolrooms.³⁸

The image of Emancipator belonged particularly to American Negroes. They had come to honor, love, and revere Lincoln during his lifetime. The demonstration in the streets of Richmond was only the

most dramatic instance of that worship. The New Year's Day reception at the White House in 1865 was remarkable for the attendance of Negroes for the first time. The President welcomed them, it was reported, "with a heartiness that made them wild with exceeding joy. They laughed and wept, and wept and laughed, exclaiming through their blinding tears, 'God bless you!' 'God bless Abraham Lincoln!' 'God bless Massa Linkum!'" Already Negroes were beginning to celebrate the anniversary of the Emancipation Proclamation as their "independence day." No people had more cause to mourn the President's death. Like the Christ of "The Battle Hymn of the Republic," he had died to make them free. Every Negro church was clad in black for his funeral; everybody wore bands of black crepe, or made do with strips cut from bonnets or flour sacks dipped in chimney soot. Soon Lincoln's bust might be seen on church altars. Negroes were among the very first to propose raising a monument to him.

But the image of Lincoln as Emancipator was not the exclusive possession of Negroes, nor was it limited to the historical act of the emancipation of the slaves. For the act was taken as the harbinger of a new era of freedom for oppressed humanity everywhere. The foreign response to Lincoln's death showed that. William Lloyd Garrison, the Massachusetts abolitionist leader who, with many of his followers, had begun by damning Lincoln but ended by praising him, understood it. "And, after all," he asked when addressing the annual meeting of the American Anti-Slavery Society three weeks after the assassination, "what was it that endeared Lincoln to mankind so universally? It was not simply that he came from among the people, a 'rail-splitter,' reaching the highest position in our country; it was not simply that he was an honest and amiable man; it was the consciousness that he incarnated in his position, and in his heart, the great cause of universal freedom."³⁹

The image of Lincoln as Man of the People had two main aspects. First, it represented him as one of the plain people, a child of poverty and toil, rough-grained like the country he inhabited. As Richard H. Stoddard visualized him in his Horatian ode:

A laboring man, with horny hands,
Who swung the axe, who tilled the lands—
One of the people, born to be
Their conscious epitome.

He was not a remote and splendid figure, like Washington or Napoleon. He seemed more like Cromwell, warts and all, some writers suggested. All agreed, fundamentally, that he was unlike anyone who had before appeared on the world stage. Lincoln was a new kind of hero, the dem-

ocratic hero, "elevated from the people, without affluence, without position, either social or political, with nothing to commend him but his own heart and sagacious mind." Editor Greeley, of the *New York Tribune*, whose political bouts with Lincoln were notorious, observed just after his death that, Lincoln being essentially a commoner, "the masses thought of him as one with whom they had been splitting rails on a pleasant Spring day or making a prosperous voyage down the Mississippi on an Illinois flat-boat, and found him a downright good fellow." Other Presidents may have sprung from the common people, but none was so absolutely one with them, instinct with their humanity, Greeley thought. There was a paradox here, however, for nobody believed that Lincoln was merely a popular type. He was rather, an uncommon common man: the peerless democrat.⁴⁰

The other facet of the image celebrated Lincoln's faith in democracy, his shrewdness as a popular leader, his uncanny reading of the public mind, and his ability to inspire trust in people. The fact that he succeeded in his perilous task, that he trusted the people and, no less important, that the people had the wit to trust him, was the ultimate test, in European eyes, of the fledgling democratic experiment in America. It was axiomatic in Europe that great power corrupted the state and its rulers. Lincoln disproved that. His record was not spotless, but he had used extraordinary power responsibly for virtuous ends. Greeley still felt that Lincoln had suffered as a wartime leader from excesses of patience, constancy, and leniency. In the general opinion, however, these attributes contributed to his democratic genius. "It was the surest proof of Mr. Lincoln's sagacity and the deliberate reach of his understanding," Lowell wrote, "that he never thought time wasted while he waited for the wagon that brought his supplies. The very immovability of his purpose, fixed always on what was attainable, laid him open to the shallow criticism of having none—for a shooting star draws more eyes . . . than a planet—but it gained him at last such a following as made him irresistible." The writer George H. Boker voiced the same sentiment in his verse epitaph:

Great in his goodness, humble in his state,
Firm in his purpose, yet not passionate,
He led the people with a tender hand,
And won by love a sway beyond command.

The model American democrat had also, at Gettysburg, offered a definition of democracy, "government of the people, by the people, for the

people," that was as deep as it was succinct—one that would capture the imagination of popular leaders the world over.⁴¹

The idea of Lincoln as the First American received its classic statement in Lowell's "Commemoration Ode," written for the Harvard Commencement in July 1865. In this long meditation on the heroic dead, on freedom, and on the nation's promise, the poet laid his wreath at the urn of the Martyr Chief:

Nature, they say, doth dote,
And cannot make a man
Save on some worn-out plan,
Repeating as by rote:
For him her Old-World moulds aside she threw,
And, choosing sweet clay from the breast
Of the unexhausted West,
With stuff untainted shaped a hero new,
Wise, steadfast in the strength of God, and true.

Lowell went on to evoke a man of "clear-grained human worth," for whom "outward grace is dust," and concluded the tribute:

Great captains, with their guns and drums,
Disturb our judgment for the hour,
But at last silence comes;
These are all gone, and, standing like a tower,
Our children shall behold his fame,
The kindly, earnest, brave, foreseeing man
Sagacious, patient, dreading praise, not blame,
New birth of our soil, the first American.

Lowell never met Lincoln, and he appears in the poem as an idea rather than a flesh-and-blood human being. Nor, in fact, did the poet recite this encomium at Harvard; it was added prior to publication, and would be remembered long after the rest of the ode was forgotten. There were, of course, many intimations of Lincoln's Americanism. Lowell himself had hinted at it in his 1864 essay. His literary friend Nathaniel Hawthorne had described the President as "the pattern American" after an interview in 1862, though Hawthorne's Boston editor thought the portrait too indelicate for publication while Lincoln lived. Brooks, in his sermon the day Lincoln lay in state in Independence Hall, called him "the best and most American of all Americans," while the editorial writer for the *New York Herald* said Lincoln was "as indigenous to our soil as the cranberry crop."⁴²

In Lincoln, it was sometimes said, were the characteristic lineaments of each of the great sections of the country. He was the veritable specimen, physically, of the Yankee, as Hawthorne noted. By birth and parentage he was a southerner, whence he may have derived his keen understanding of the South. Above all, he was a westerner, his mind "genial, level-lined, fruitful and friendly," like the prairie, Lowell said. The first President whose entire life was western, he brought to his work habits of mind and character bred by a new country. Much was said of his plainness and simplicity. "His simple presence," Sumner remarked, "was like a Proclamation of Human Equality." Many marveled at the entire absence in him of vanity and affectation, malice and guile. He was open, candid, and honest. "Honest Abe" was more than a political slogan; it was God's truth. An engraver published a memento of Lincoln's death in which Diogenes with his lantern appears above a medallion portrait of Lincoln. The inscription reads:

Diogenes his lantern needs no more;
An honest man is found; the work is o'er.

Certain traits of character, such as kindness and charity, added to the wonderful individuality of Abraham Lincoln, though there was nothing "western" about them. One defining trait, humor, with a pungent western accent, was scarcely noticed amid the solemnities of Lincoln's death. In years to come, however, it would add a bold and salty strain to Lincoln's Americanness, indeed his folksiness, as the people went about the work of discovering themselves in the mirror held up to Lincoln.⁴³

The final image, in a sense the central myth of the Lincoln epic, was that of the Self-made Man. Although by no means the first of the type, Lincoln, unancestried, unprivileged, uneducated, unknown, incarnated the ideal. "No man ever lived, who was more a self-made man than President Lincoln," wrote a biographer just after his death. "Self-made or never made" was the homey adage, and Lincoln himself took pride in the success story he had become. "I happen, temporarily, to occupy the White House," he remarked in a little address in 1864. "I am a living witness that any of your children may look to come here as my father's child has."

The campaign biographies of 1860 hinted at the conception, but it took flight in William M. Thayer's *The Pioneer Boy and How He Became President* in 1863. Twenty-six thousand copies were sold within two years, when fire destroyed the plates. Although intended especially for young readers, the book appealed to all ages. Viewing the phenomenon of Lincoln's rise, Thayer asked, "How was it done?" And he answered that



Diogenes His Lantern Needs No More. Engraving by M. B. Hall, 1865. (The Lincoln Museum, Fort Wayne, a part of Lincoln National Corporation)

Lincoln's success followed from practicing the proven virtues of honesty, kindness, temperance, industry, and pluck. The moral and educational value of the story was inestimable. It centered, of course, not on what Lincoln did or said, but on what Lincoln was, in short on his personal character. Parson Weems, in his famous *Life of George Washington*, which the "pioneer boy" had so much admired, summing up the greatness of Washington had put little stock in his public attainments. "Oh

no! give us his private virtues! In these, every youth may become a Washington—a Washington in piety and patriotism—in industry and honor—and consequently a Washington in what alone deserves the name, SELF ESTEEM AND UNIVERSAL RESPECT." What most deserved the name in Lincoln's life was the triumph of the virtues of American democratic character.⁴⁴

The five themes here set forth would be developed, entwined, embellished, revised, and recast, through several generations. While not all-inclusive, they are the guiding themes in the nation's memory of Abraham Lincoln, and, although changeable, they are remarkably resilient. The public remembrance of the past, as differentiated from the historical scholars', is concerned less with establishing its truth than with appropriating it for the present. It relies on written records, but it draws as well upon oral tradition and personal reminiscence, upon stories endlessly repeated, and upon the meanings conveyed by pictorial images, patriotic rituals, and sanctified sites. While heightening consciousness of the nation's heritage, it restages the past and manipulates it for ongoing public purposes. History, as a critical science, is only a later phase of the enterprise. The magnitude of Lincoln's achievement combined with the drama of his death made his memory especially important to the American people. He was a masterpiece, a national treasure to be preserved, loved, revered, and emulated. "It may be," said one memorialist, "that one purpose of that strange manner of summoning him to the skies was to . . . engrave his traits all the deeper into the memories of coming generations." To which Phillips Brooks, in his great sermon, added the ultimate benediction: "May God make us worthy of the memory of Abraham Lincoln."⁴⁵